

Chapter 71 Part 3

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The road to Ci'ai Nursing Home¹ wasn't too boring, though the atmosphere was somewhat heavy.

Although Xu Qingzhu spoke lightly about how she might come to terms with it one day, Liang Shi still heard the fragility beneath her feigned composure.

She must be afraid.

But unwilling to show others her fear.

Liang Shi didn't express any more opinions on the matter, instead saying to her: "Teacher Xu, no matter what decision you make, I'll support you."

After a pause, she added: "Just like how you support me."

"I haven't really supported you either." Xu Qingzhu said calmly: "It's just pure curiosity."

Xu Qingzhu attributed everything she had done to curiosity rather than helping Liang Shi, trying to lighten Liang Shi's psychological burden.

Liang Shi accepted this sentiment, but secretly made a resolution.

—To uncover the truth.

If one day Xu Qingzhu wanted to know the truth buried beneath the surface of her current life, then she would provide that truth.

If Xu Qingzhu didn't want to know, then she would bury that truth completely.

From the city center to Ci'ai Nursing Home, they had to travel through a long stretch of mountain road. During this time, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu switched positions.

One person driving for too long could lead to drowsy driving. After driving for nearly an hour, they finally arrived at Ci'ai Nursing Home.

Ci'ai Nursing Home backed onto a large mountain. Now in late autumn, the mountain had turned a withered yellow, and the road at the nursing home's entrance was covered with fallen leaves.

In summer, this place should be quite comfortable.

Liang Shi parked the car by the roadside. After Xu Qingzhu got out, they headed toward the entrance together.

The gatekeepers were two young security guards. One sat in the security room playing games, while the other sat at the entrance with a red classroom desk in front of him, on which sat a visitor registration book.

The one sitting at the entrance had his phone propped up, watching a TV drama.

It happened to be Zhao Ying's drama. He watched with a foolish grin.

Liang Shi walked over and asked: "Hello, I'd like to ask..."

Before she could finish, the security guard interrupted, "Who are you here to see? Register first."

Liang Shi said: "I'm looking for the director. Is he here?"

"Looking for the director?" The security guard paused his TV drama. "Who are you? What do you need the director for?"

Liang Shi said: "I have some things I'd like to ask about."

The security guard frowned: "What things? Our director is very busy."

"It's fine." Xu Qingzhu said: "We'll just call him ourselves."

The security guard looked at the two of them with an expression of utter speechlessness.

Xu Qingzhu had gotten the director's phone number from Lin Luoxi and called him. He quickly came out from his office.

Liang Shi once again experienced what it meant to have connections that make things easier.

The reason Xu Qingzhu gave the director for her visit was that she wanted to see the current management of Hazhou City's nursing homes and their material needs.

If necessary, she could provide funding.

This nursing home didn't really need funding, but Xu Qingzhu had learned from Lin Luoxi that the director currently had the idea of rebuilding an orphanage, so he would need money.

He would also need attention from various sectors of society, so the director would make friends widely.

The director wasn't tall, was lean, wore black-framed glasses, dressed in casual sportswear, and had new running shoes on his feet. When he came to meet them, he even jogged a few steps.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu each introduced themselves, and also learned that this director's surname was Gu, given name Zhaoyuan.

All the information matched what Xu Qingzhu had learned from Lin Luoxi beforehand.

Gu Zhaoyuan's father had founded Angel Orphanage back then, taking in abandoned infants and disabled children from Hazhou City. Some children with better prospects were adopted by wealthy and powerful families, all through anonymous adoption.

Later, Gu Zhaoyuan's father fell seriously ill and converted Angel Orphanage into Ci'ai Nursing Home. At once, it transformed from a money-losing orphanage into a profitable nursing home. Moreover, many of those children who had grown up in Angel Orphanage became employees of Ci'ai Nursing Home.

Most of these people were disabled individuals who couldn't find work in society.

Because they hadn't accepted new children for many years, the youngest of the last batch of children who entered Angel Orphanage was already 15 years old this year.

And after the nursing home became profitable, Gu Zhaoyuan would send school-age children to study. The children would work at the nursing home in their spare time, and their pocket money came from their wages.

In a sense, the orphanage and nursing home had achieved a balance.

With this model already in place, Gu Zhaoyuan's mind became active again, wanting to reestablish an orphanage. This was because he himself was an abandoned infant who had been adopted by the previous director and became his adopted son, inheriting this nursing home.

In fact, the old Director Gu had never married or had children. He had devoted all his energy in the first half of his life to building the orphanage, and Gu Zhaoyuan, influenced by him, planned to make this work his lifelong faith.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu followed him as they toured the nursing home, learning about the nursing home's history and current development from him.

Footnotes:

¹ Ci'ai Nursing Home (慈愛養老院, Cí'ài Yǎnglǎoyuàn): "Ci'ai" literally means "loving kindness/compassionate love." The name reflects the caring nature of the facility.